

Pennsylvania & West Nile Virus

These are easy measures that everyone can take in their own back yards to help protect themselves and their family from the West Nile virus.

DEP offers the following tips to eliminate mosquito-breeding sites around the home:

- Identify and eliminate standing water that collects on your property. Mosquitoes will breed in any puddle that lasts for more than four days.
- Dispose of tin cans, plastic containers, ceramic pots or similar water holding containers, including those that have become overgrown by aquatic vegetation.
- Empty water that may accumulate in discarded tires.
- Drill holes in the bottom of recycling containers that are left outside.
- Have clogged roof gutters cleaned annually, particularly if the leaves from surrounding trees tend to block the drains.
- Turn over plastic wading pools when not in use.
- Turn over wheelbarrows and do not allow water to stagnate in birdbaths.
- Aerate ornamental pools or stock them with fish.
- Keep swimming pools clean and chlorinated, and prevent water from collecting on swimming pool covers.

DEP and county West Nile coordinators monitor the type, location and population of immature (larvae and pupae) and adult mosquitoes. This information is then used to treat those areas where high populations of mosquitoes that are known West Nile carriers are found.

Pennsylvania's aggressive approach has contributed to a drop in the number of human West Nile virus cases. The West Nile virus can cause West Nile fever and encephalitis—an infection that can cause inflammation of the brain and death—when transmitted to people.

Last year, the West Nile virus was found in 25 Pennsylvania counties. Ten state residents contracted the virus, but no deaths were reported. In 2006, two of the nine Pennsylvanians who contracted West Nile virus died and in 2005, 25 residents contracted the disease, with no deaths attributed to the virus.

Most people bitten by an infected mosquito will never develop any symptoms, and only one in 150 with symptoms will develop the more serious West Nile encephalitis.

Because mosquitoes acquire the virus from infected birds, residents are reminded to report dead crows, blue jays and hawks. Residents who discover dead birds and would like to submit them for testing should call the local West Nile county coordinator.

When handling dead birds, use rubber gloves. If you do not have gloves, insert your hand into a plastic bag, grasp the bird carefully and invert the bag over the bird. Each bird should be placed in a tied plastic bag and then placed inside a second tied bag.

If you are not submitting the bird for testing, place the bagged bird in the trash. Wash your hands with soap and water.

For more information about West Nile virus, and register for updates via e-mail, visit www.westnile.state.pa.us. People can also call 1-877-PA-HEALTH for information